

Draft: DEC 24 2025

THE POWER OF SERENDIPITY
January 30 2026 –March 10 2026

Draft Course Outline

Friday January 30: Introduction: Setting the scene: What is serendipity? Why is it such an important force both personally, and for companies? Examples will be explored and discussed, as will the structure, objectives and deliverables for the course.

Tuesday Feb 3: The “100-year-life”: How longer, healthier lives are transforming careers, and have converted the historic three-stage life of 20-years learning/education, 40-years working, and a lucky few years of restful retirement into a wholly new norm. This will be structured around a 60-year career which will include self-managed life-time learning, a new “blurred” concept of “retirement”, and wholly new challenges managing how you finance your life.

Friday Feb 6: Managing risk: many companies and company executives have a poor sense of the range and seriousness of risks that can disrupt and derail them. Routine, technical and run-of-the-mill risks are normally well-managed, but how can a company equip itself to identify, anticipate, prioritise and manage the “black swans” – wars, pandemics and other “unknown unknowns”, which by definition may be impossible to anticipate, despite their potential to inflict colossal harm. Recent wars and the Covid pandemic have vividly illustrated the scale of the challenge. What can be done to anticipate and manage these worst-of-all threats? This session will examine recent experience to identify some basic answers.

Friday Feb 10: Global warming and climate change: the reality of global warming may have been formally acknowledged around a scientific consensus forged 30 years ago, but it is only now that governments, companies and communities are beginning to wrestle seriously with the challenges. Despite evidence of moderate progress, the Trump administration’s dismissal of climate change as a “colossal hoax” has jeopardized progress, with potentially alarming consequences. Executives face massive challenges in navigating the global warming issue, but are set to play an indispensable role in charting a 25-year course to “Net Zero”.

Tuesday Feb 13: Trade, Globalisation and multilateralism in flux: After a 60-year period of relative peace, and steady corporate globalization shaped by international rules set by the WW2 “Bretton Woods” institutions, the past decade has seen massive systemic changes driven by protectionism, nationalism, angst about “national security”, a marginalization of the World Trade Organisation, and challenges to multilateral cooperation. How do companies navigate this profound change, whether they are SMEs, or large multinationals with complex supply and production chains?

Chinese New Year break

Tuesday Feb 24: The Technology revolution and identifying the skills of the future: the technological revolution of the past 30 years is deepening and accelerating, with profound influences on every aspect of personal and corporate lives. Anticipating the workplace skills

needed even a decade from now has become a challenge. How do companies chart these profound technological transformations to their advantage?

Friday Feb 27: Asia and the “Global South” – shifting economic power: for most of the past 200 years, careers have been primarily driven and dominated by the economic activity of a small number of European and American companies and governments. Recent rapid growth of economies like China and India, but also including countries like Japan, South Korea, Brazil, Nigeria, South Africa and Indonesia, is transforming this two-century paradigm, pointing to a more complex “multi-polar” world economy and a shifting balance of economic power that will transform how companies grow and succeed.

Tuesday Mar 3: Demographics, diversity, equity and inclusion: in most countries, new technologies and hectic social change (including pressures to facilitate work from home, and pressures to improve diversity in the workplace) are generating a wide range of new challenges for companies worldwide. The working-age population is dwindling in absolute terms in many countries, altering the balance of economic growth and power away from the currently-dominant “Global North”. Within countries, as fewer children are growing into the workforce, and more people are living into deep old age, staff and skills shortages are driving a wholly-new approach to ageing populations and “retirement”. How are these developments likely to evolve and how should businesses navigate the international business challenges that arise?

Friday Mar 6: Trust and effective communication: Building and keeping stakeholder trust is an indispensable factor underpinning corporate success. Once lost, it is not easily rebuilt. How can a company most effectively build and retain trust? A key to maintaining trust is good communication, but many executives give scant attention to effective communication. Too often it is muddled with marketing, and it rarely takes account of the imperative to communicate effectively with all stakeholders with influence on, or an interest in, a company.

Tuesday Mar 10: Conclusion: Executives beginning careers today face challenges that are quite literally unprecedented. Some of these challenges can be rehearsed and prepared for, but the present “polycrisis” has brought together many challenges that cannot be anticipated. How you manage the unexpected and unexpectable is likely to determine the shape and success of your career. This course aims to sensitise and prepare you to wrestle with – and hopefully even capture advantage from – the unanticipatable power of serendipity.